

7 Reasons for US military involvement in Vietnam, 1954-63

Control of Vietnam

Vietnam is a small country in southeast Asia that had a big impact on the USA in the 1960s and 1970s. The USA also had a big impact on Vietnam.

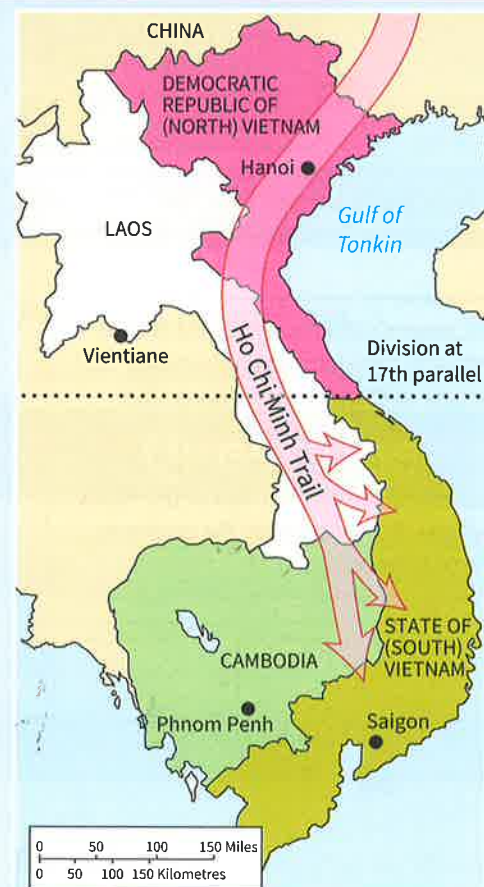
Before that time, Vietnam had been controlled by different countries, leading to war there.

Prior to 1940	During the Second World War	After 1945
Vietnam kingdoms become part of the French Empire in Asia, known as French Indochina.	- Japan captures Vietnam in 1940. - Leader Ho Chi Minh forms the Vietminh, a left-wing group, to fight for an independent Vietnam.	- France tries to reclaim Vietnam. - The Vietminh resist, using guerrilla tactics, leading to a nine-year war with France. - Communist China supports the Vietminh. - The USA supports France. By 1954, the USA is paying 80% of France's war costs.

The end of French rule in Vietnam

- Between March and May 1954, French and Vietminh forces fought in the Battle of Dien Bien Phu.
- The battle ended in defeat for the French, and they were forced to leave Vietnam.
- France asked the USA for help.

The division of Vietnam



After the French defeat, a conference was organised in Geneva in 1954 to sort out the situation. Representatives from Vietnam, France, China, the UK, the USA, and the USSR attended.

The agreements reached at the Geneva Conference were summarised in ten documents known as the Geneva Accords:

- French Indochina would be split into four independent countries (see map): Laos, Cambodia, the Democratic Republic of (North) Vietnam, and the State of (South) Vietnam.
- Vietnam would be divided at the 17th parallel.
- The pro-communist Vietminh would control the northern Democratic Republic of Vietnam under President Ho Chi Minh.
- An anti-communist government under Ngo Dinh Diem would control the southern State of Vietnam. (Diem was Catholic; Vietnam was mostly Buddhist.)
- After two years, elections would reunite the country.

Key terms

Make sure you can write a definition for these key terms

guerrilla
Cold War communism
domino theory
Vietcong counterinsurgency
CIA ARVN

▲ Map of French Indochina after the Geneva Accords, July 1954

Reasons for greater US involvement in Vietnam under Eisenhower

After the Second World War, the USA engaged in a **Cold War** against **communism**.

- Ho Chi Minh was popular and the USA feared that he could win the democratic elections for the Vietminh.
- The Vietminh was influenced by communism from the USSR and Russia. The US government saw communism as a dangerous ideology that would spread to other Asian countries. This was known as the **domino theory** (countries would fall to communism, one after the other, like a row of dominoes).
- The US government gave money and military support to Diem's government to try to stop communism spreading. It also sent advisers to train the State of (South) Vietnam's military.
- Both Eisenhower and Kennedy wanted to appear 'tough on communism'.

Diem's government

Backed by the USA, Diem refused to hold the elections promised in 1956. His government became increasingly corrupt and less democratic.

- In October 1955, US officials supported fixed elections to confirm Diem's position.
- Diem's government took advantage of US support to treat opponents brutally and get rich from US aid (about \$1.5 billion between 1954 and 1960), neglecting the poor lower classes.
- Anger and resentment built in South Vietnam, particularly as Buddhists were persecuted.
- Protests started against Diem, and opposition to his regime increased.
- In 1957, 65 000 suspected communists were arrested and 2000 were killed. Revenge attacks targeted Diem's officials.
- The Vietminh established the **Vietcong** in South Vietnam: guerrilla soldiers funded by the North to bring down Diem's government and unite the whole country.
- In May 1959, with Chinese backing, the Vietminh sent military aid to the Vietcong.

Reasons for greater US involvement in Vietnam under Kennedy

By early 1961, over half of South Vietnam was under the control of the 12 000 Vietcong.

President Kennedy increased US involvement in Vietnam to support **counterinsurgency** measures.

As a result of the 'Strategic Hamlet Program', Vietcong membership tripled between 1962 and 1964.

- Kennedy wants to be seen as 'tough on communism', as his election victory in 1960 was very close.
- Kennedy increases support to South Vietnam from 700 US military advisers to 16 000 by the end of 1963, and financial support by around \$40 million.
- Kennedy supports Diem's 'Strategic Hamlet Program', moving peasants into new fortified villages in areas under the control of the **ARVN** (Army of the Republic of Vietnam).
- Kennedy instructs the **CIA** to help with the 'Strategic Hamlet Program', but it is very unpopular with peasants.
- Diem's unpopularity in the South is clear. The CIA encourages Diem's generals to lead a coup against him. Diem is arrested and shot in November 1963.

Retrieval

Learn the answers to the questions below, then cover the answers column with a piece of paper and write down as many as you can. Check and repeat until you know them all.

Questions

- Which two countries controlled Indochina in the first half of the twentieth century?
- In which battle did the Vietminh defeat the French, leading to the French withdrawal?
- Who was the leader of the Vietminh and first President of North Vietnam?
- Who was the leader of South Vietnam after the partition of the country in 1954?
- What was the domino theory?
- Why did Kennedy take a more aggressive approach to Vietnam than Eisenhower had?
- What was the 'Strategic Hamlet Program'?
- How did Kennedy escalate the US presence in Vietnam?
- What happened to Diem in November 1963?
- What was the impact of the 'Strategic Hamlet Program'?

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Answers

- France and Japan
- Battle of Dien Bien Phu
- Ho Chi Minh
- Ngo Dinh Diem
- The US belief that if one country became communist others nearby would follow, one after the other, like a row of dominoes
- Kennedy had won a close election in 1960 and wanted to show that he was 'tough on communism'
- A State of Vietnam policy supported by Kennedy and the CIA, which moved peasants into new fortified villages in areas controlled by the ARVN
- He increased support for Diem's regime from 700 military advisers to 16 000 and increased funding by around \$40 million
- He was removed by his own generals in a coup encouraged by the CIA, arrested, and shot dead
- It was very unpopular and, as a result, Vietcong membership tripled within three years

Previous questions

Use the questions below to check your knowledge from previous chapters.

Questions

- What was CORE's primary tactic in the fight for civil rights?
- How were Black people treated by the police and the legal system?
- What key areas did the 1968 Civil Rights Act address?

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Answers

- Non-violent direct action
- Police officers and the legal system racially discriminated against Black people in both the north and south
- Housing, workers' civil rights, and punishments for rioting

Practice

7

Exam-style questions

Study Source A below and then answer Question 1.

Source A: Vietnamese Buddhist monk Thích Quảng Đức being doused with gasoline outside the Cambodian Embassy in Saigon on 11 June 1963. Shortly afterwards, he set himself on fire as a protest against Diem's rule. US reporters had been tipped off to encourage their presence.



- Give **two** things you can infer from Source A about Diem's rule in South Vietnam.

(4)

Complete the table below to explain your answer.

- (i) What I can infer:
Details in the source that tell me this:
- (ii) What I can infer:
Details in the source that tell me this:

- Explain why the USA was concerned about the future of Vietnam in 1963.

(12)

You **may** use the following in your answer:

- the division of the country into North and South
- Diem's government

You **must** also use information of your own.

EXAM TIP

When answering question 2, remember P-E-E:

- Make your **Point**.
- Back it up with **Evidence** from your historical knowledge.
- Then **Explain** why your chosen point caused the result in the question.

Do this three times and you'll have your answer! You can add an introductory paragraph if you wish, but there is no need to add a conclusion.



8 The escalation of the conflict in Vietnam under Johnson

The increasing threat of the Vietcong

The removal of Diem failed to stop support for the Vietcong growing.

- In November 1963, President Kennedy was assassinated. Vice President Lyndon Johnson replaced him, then won the 1964 presidential election.
- The Vietcong were increasingly successful in expanding their influence in South Vietnam through both **propaganda** and presence.

Propaganda	Presence
- The Vietcong spread propaganda amongst the population. - Its members claimed to fight to end poverty and injustice, and to unite Vietnam. - They lived with villagers, introduced social reforms, and showed the people respect.	- By the end of 1964, around two-thirds of South Vietnam was under Vietcong control. - The Vietcong had around 100 000 soldiers, but also much more civilian support. - Vietcong bases were established in jungles throughout the South. - The Vietcong operated amongst, and blended into, the local population. - Supply routes brought weapons from China and the USSR overland along the Ho Chi Minh trail through Laos and Cambodia (see page 28), and by sea. - Between 1955 and 1963, China sent North Vietnam over \$100 million in aid.
- Members of the ARVN were portrayed as weak and puppets of the USA. - South Vietnamese villagers resented being relocated into hamlets.	- The ARVN and US troops totalled around 550 000 soldiers by the end of 1964. - The South Vietnamese government was divided by in-fighting after Diem's removal, and was not fully focused on fighting the war. - The USA's presence was increasingly unpopular in South Vietnam and was linked to the failing regime.

The Gulf of Tonkin incident, 1964

Johnson wanted to increase efforts to contain communism in Vietnam. An attack on a US ship in the Gulf of Tonkin gave him the chance: - USS <i>Maddox</i> was attacked by North Vietnamese torpedo boats on 2 August 1964. - Further follow-up attacks on <i>Maddox</i> and USS <i>Turner Joy</i> were claimed on 4 August, but have since been disproved.	These 'attacks' were followed by US aircraft bombing North Vietnam. - Johnson had warned against more 'unprovoked' attacks'. He now asked Congress to pass a resolution for military action and for political and financial support against aggression. - Congress agreed, with only two votes against.	President Johnson signed the Tonkin Resolution (10 August 1964): - It gave Johnson power to 'take all necessary measures to repel any armed attack against the forces of the United States and to prevent further aggression' - It pushed North Vietnam into further aiding the Vietcong.
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The nature of the conflict in Vietnam, 1964-68

- US tactics were designed to exploit the USA's aerial superiority and destroy North Vietnam's ability to wage war.
- However, the Vietcong did not fight a conventional war, and proved a challenging opponent. The Vietcong used guerrilla tactics to great effect.

Guerrilla tactic	Why it was effective
No uniforms	This meant members of the Vietcong were hard to identify. They were indistinguishable from peasants, and soldiers were afraid of killing innocent people.
Peasants	Vietcong guerrillas gained support by being very respectful and never stealing from peasants.
Punishing traitors	The Vietcong were generous to those who helped them but brutal to those who helped the enemy. Some 30 000 collaborators were executed during the war.
Tunnels	Complex tunnel systems that had been used against the French and Japanese were expanded. The tunnels offered protection against bombing, storage, and shelter, and were hard to find and target with counter-attacks.
Booby traps	Ingenious and vicious traps such as punji stick pits, grenade traps, snake pits, bamboo whips, and mines were a danger to US soldiers. During the Vietnam War, 11% of US deaths and 15% of injuries were caused by booby traps.
Ambushes	The Vietcong launched hit-and-run surprise attacks, before melting away into the jungle, keeping their enemy in constant fear of attack. They also sabotaged roads and bridges to interrupt transport links, and targeted military equipment.
Ho Chi Minh Trail	This ensured Vietcong bases in the South could be resupplied. As the trail went through neighbouring Laos and Cambodia, the USA could not attack it directly.

From November 1964, the Vietcong in the South received greater support from the North. Those fighting for the Vietcong were urged to attack US bases, not just the ARVN.

The Vietcong's guerrilla tactics brought successes with minimal casualties.

December 1964/January 1965:

Vietcong victory at Binh Gia:

- some 50 US helicopters destroyed
- around 200 US/ARVN troops killed
- the death of only 32 Vietcong soldiers.

7 February 1965:

Vietcong raid Pleiku airfield in a five-minute attack:

- over 120 US/ARVN casualties
- at least 20 aircraft damaged
- the death of only one Vietcong soldier.



8 The escalation of the conflict in Vietnam under Johnson

Methods used by the USA

By February 1965, US involvement in Vietnam was costing \$2 million a day. Over 180 000 US troops had been sent to Vietnam, and almost 2000 had been killed in action.

The USA used three main methods of fighting the Vietcong. These tactics were destructive and caused a lot of **collateral damage**, increasing local resentment.

1

Search and Destroy

From March 1965: Increasing numbers of US ground troops were sent to Vietnam. They used 'search and destroy' tactics.

- US troops entered villages searching for Vietcong camps and supplies. If evidence was found, the villages were destroyed by fire or bombing.
- Some missions succeeded, but they made US troops susceptible to booby traps, and alienated locals.
- As soon as the US troops left, the Vietcong moved back in; around three million South Vietnamese were made homeless.
- Johnson had to use the **draft** to forcibly recruit soldiers, causing resentment in the USA.

2

Operation Rolling Thunder

From 2 March 1965 to 2 November 1968: A **strategic** bombing campaign called Operation Rolling Thunder was waged against military and industrial areas in North Vietnam and the Ho Chi Minh Trail.

- Johnson initially set the target areas, but the scope widened as resistance continued.
- 643 000 tonnes of bombs were dropped over 3.5 years.
- It cost \$900 million but only caused around \$300 million in damage; 900 US aircraft were shot down.
- It led to 52 000 casualties, over 34 000 of whom were civilians. This made the USA look barbaric and only served to strengthen Ho Chi Minh's resolve.
- It failed to stop use of the Trail, as it was constantly repaired, and the tunnels protected soldiers/supplies.
- It failed to disrupt war supplies, as most came from China and the USSR, countries the USA did not want to risk conflict with.

3

Chemical weapons

From 1962 to 1971: Operation Ranch Hand oversaw the aerial spraying of **defoliants** over South Vietnam.

- Powerful herbicides were used to clear jungle plants and crops.
- Some 3000 villages over 4.5 million acres were sprayed, often with the villagers still in residence.
- Agent Orange was used to destroy the jungle and expose Vietcong bases and supply routes.
- Agent Blue was used to kill crops.
- The defoliants damaged soil and harmed people for decades, with high incidences of skin disease, miscarriage, cancer, birth defects, and malformations reported.
- Napalm**, an **incendiary** designed to burn anything on contact, was also used extensively. Its use against civilians was banned in 1980.

Increased US involvement in Vietnam

The late 1960s saw increased US involvement in the war in Vietnam, and a corresponding increase in spending:

	1964	1965	1968
Number of US troops sent to Vietnam	23 000	184 000	536 000
Number of US troops killed in the war	206	1863	16 592
US cost of the Vietnam War	\$500 million	\$700 million	\$26 266 million



The Tet Offensive, 1968

There were few large-scale battles in the Vietnam War. The biggest – and most significant – was the Tet Offensive of January and February 1968.

The Tet Lunar New Year was one of Vietnam's biggest holidays, and a ceasefire usually took place during the festival. The Vietcong attack took US and ARVN forces by surprise.

Areas near the border are attacked to lure the US and ARVN troops north.

The Vietcong attack 13 cities in South Vietnam. Most ARVN troops are not on duty because of the holiday.

Vietcong troops are forced out of Hue. US and ARVN forces find evidence of a massacre. Over 500 US marines and ARVN are killed reclaiming Hue's ancient citadel, filmed by numerous TV crews.

Late 1967

21 Jan 1968

30 Jan 1968

31 Jan 1968

24 Feb 1968

27 Feb 1968

North Vietnamese troops attack the US base at Khe Sanh. The USA sends 6000 troops to defend the base.

North Vietnamese and Vietcong forces strike more than 120 cities, towns, and military bases throughout South Vietnam. 19 Vietcong attack the US embassy in the capital, Saigon. Although 18 are killed, they briefly hold the bottom floor of the embassy.

The leading TV news reporter in the USA, Walter Cronkite, suggests in a report that the war is unwinnable. President Johnson allegedly responds: 'If I've lost Cronkite, I've lost middle America.'

Although initially very successful, the communist forces were spread thin, and US and ARVN forces countered most of the attacks successfully.

Significance of the Tet Offensive

By 1968, public opinion in the USA was turning against the war in Vietnam. The Tet Offensive was a crucial factor, resulting in almost 13 000 US and ARVN casualties. The US media and public believed the war could not be won, despite heavy Vietcong losses.

Impact of the Tet Offensive

... on the Vietcong	... on South Vietnam	... on the USA
- The USA estimated 60 000 communist troops were killed (a figure since revised down). It was a significant blow to the Vietcong's military capacity. - The Vietcong gained no new ground in South Vietnam. - The offensive failed to provoke an uprising of support among the peasants in South Vietnam.	- The ARVN proved they could be an effective fighting force. - The offensive showed the ARVN had some support, as there was no uprising against them. - The offensive highlighted the destruction of a communist takeover: almost 8000 civilians died, and 75 000 homes were destroyed.	- The invasion of the US embassy shocked many Americans, who thought the USA was winning. - US General Westmoreland requested a further 200 000 troops to launch a counteroffensive, but only 10 500 were sent. - US public opinion became more strongly anti-war. Protests in the USA increased, as the end of the war was not in sight. - By late 1968, Westmoreland and Johnson had left their roles. Johnson announced he would not stand for President again.

Key terms

Make sure you can write a definition for these key terms

propaganda morale collateral damage
draft strategic defoliant napalm incendiary

Learn the answers to the questions below, then cover the answers column with a piece of paper and write down as many as you can. Check and repeat until you know them all.

Questions

Answers

- | | | |
|----|--|---|
| 1 | Which event in 1964 involved attacks on the American naval destroyer USS <i>Maddox</i> ? | The Gulf of Tonkin incident |
| 2 | What happened after the attacks in the Gulf of Tonkin? | Congress agreed to give Johnson the authority to escalate the war in Vietnam |
| 3 | What was the Ho Chi Minh Trail? | A route from North to South Vietnam used to resupply guerrilla groups in the South |
| 4 | Name the way of fighting used by the small groups of Vietcong. | Guerrilla warfare |
| 5 | How did the Vietcong treat South Vietnamese people working with the USA? | The Vietcong were brutal to those seen as traitors; around 30 000 collaborators were executed |
| 6 | What was 'search and destroy'? | A US military tactic that involved US troops entering villages hunting Vietcong; if evidence of Vietcong was found, the villages were destroyed |
| 7 | What was Operation Rolling Thunder? | A US strategic bombing campaign that dropped 643 000 tonnes of bombs on North Vietnam and the Ho Chi Minh Trail |
| 8 | Name two controversial chemical weapons used by the USA? | Two from: Agent Orange / Agent Blue / napalm |
| 9 | By how much did Johnson increase the US military presence in Vietnam in the four years after Tonkin? | In 1964 there were 23 000 US troops in Vietnam; by 1968 there were 536 000 US troops – an increase of 513 000 |
| 10 | Why was the Tet Offensive a surprise for the ARVN and US troops? | In previous years, there had been a ceasefire during the Tet holiday, which was the lunar new year |
| 11 | Why was the Tet Offensive a success for the Vietcong? | The US media and public believed the war could not be won, despite heavy Vietcong losses |

Previous questions

Use the questions below to check your knowledge from previous chapters.

Questions

Answers

- | | | |
|---|--|--|
| 1 | What did the Supreme Court fail to do in <i>Brown v. Topeka</i> , and what was the long-term effect? | It failed to give a deadline for integration, so progress was slow as states delayed or resisted |
| 2 | Why was the 1968 Mexico Olympics significant for the idea of 'Black Power'? | Two Black athletes gave the Black Power salute when receiving their medals, gaining widespread media attention for the cause |
| 3 | How did Kennedy escalate the US presence in Vietnam? | He increased support for Diem's regime from 700 military advisers to 16 000 and increased funding |



Exam-style questions

Study Sources A and B.

- 1 How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into the bombing campaigns during the Vietnam War? Explain your answer, using Sources A and B and your knowledge of the historical context. (8)

Source A: An extract from the book *Mission with LeMay: My Story*, published in 1965. LeMay was head of the US Air Force in 1965.

Apply whatever force it is necessary to employ, to stop things quickly. The main thing is stop it. The quicker you stop it, the more lives you save. My solution to the problem would be to tell [the North Vietnamese Communists] frankly that they've got to stop their aggression or we're going to bomb them into the Stone Age. And we would shove them back into the Stone Age with Air power or Naval power—not with ground forces.

Source B: An extract from a December 1998 interview with Robert McNamara, United States Secretary of Defense from 1961 to 1968.

No more military pressure could have been applied ... We dropped two or three times as many bombs in North and South Vietnam as were dropped by all Allied Forces throughout World War II against all enemies. It was a tremendous air effort. But there are certain things bombing can't accomplish. They can't break the will of people. They didn't break the will of the North Vietnamese. And it cannot stop the movement of the small quantities of supplies that were necessary to support the Vietcong and the North Vietnamese forces in the South.

Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about the bombing campaigns during the Vietnam War.

- 2 What is the main difference between these views? Explain your answer, using details from both interpretations (4)

Interpretation 1: Adapted from 'Was Operation Rolling Thunder a Failure?' on the US History Channel's website.

Although North Vietnam did not have much of an air force, its leaders managed to mount an effective defense using surface-to-air missiles and radar-controlled anti-aircraft artillery from China and the Soviet Union. They shot down hundreds of American planes, constructed networks of bombproof tunnels and shelters, and dispatched crews by night to rebuild damage. Additionally, the communists used the destructive air strikes for propaganda purposes to increase anti-American sentiment and patriotism among North Vietnamese citizens.

Interpretation 2: Adapted from Global Security, an independent military history and news website. It discusses the flaws of Operation Rolling Thunder.

Rolling Thunder failed to intimidate the North Vietnamese and it failed to destroy their ability to fight. It had no clear-cut objective nor did its authors have any real estimate of the cost of lives and aircraft. The failure of the American military to develop a plan consistent with the limits of war fought for limited objectives caused a crippling clash of plan and perceptions. As a result, air power was unwillingly tasked to perform a mission for which it was ill-equipped and unprepared.

- 3 Suggest **one** reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about the bombing campaigns during the Vietnam War. You may use Sources A and B to help explain your answer. (4)
- 4 How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 about the bombing campaigns during the Vietnam War? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16)

EXAM TIP

Question 4 is worth 16 marks, but there is an additional 4 marks available for spelling, punctuation and grammar. Be sure to leave time to read through your answer and check your writing.

9 Changes under Nixon, 1969-73

The Nixon Doctrine

- By August 1968, Johnson's approval ratings were down to 36%. His public appearances were met by protesters chanting 'Hey, hey, LBJ, how many kids did you kill today?'
- In the 1968 election campaign, Richard Nixon promised a plan to resolve the conflict in Vietnam.
- Nixon went on to win the 1968 presidential election with a clear majority, Johnson having withdrawn his candidacy early in the campaign due to a lack of popular support.



▲ President Richard Nixon

Election tactics	Presidential actions	
Nixon promised 'peace with honour' in Vietnam.	Nixon initiated secret talks with North Vietnam without involving or telling South Vietnam.	The USA secretly bombed the Ho Chi Minh Trail in Cambodia in March 1969.
Nixon promised to end the draft into the army.	US forces in Vietnam focused on training the ARVN.	Nixon introduced the policy of 'Vietnamisation': the USA promised military and financial aid to the ARVN whilst withdrawing US troops.
Nixon encouraged the Vietcong representative at the Paris peace talks to delay talks until after the election.	Nixon put forward the 'Nixon Doctrine' on 25 July 1969, promising US allies in Asia support, including nuclear support, but no troops.	

Vietnamisation

'Vietnamisation' was Nixon's plan to withdraw US troops without losing the war.

Although Vietnamisation reduced the US military presence in Vietnam, some feared the withdrawal was too soon for the ARVN; others felt it was not quick enough for the US troops.

Weaknesses of Vietnamisation	Strengths of Vietnamisation
The ARVN was badly led, had low morale, and was weakened by corruption and incompetence. Attempts to use US air power to shut down the Ho Chi Minh Trail failed. The remaining US troops had very low morale, drug use was high, and fragging increased (more than 300 cases, 1969-70).	60 000 US troops were withdrawn from Vietnam by late 1969. By 1971, fewer than 200 000 remained. The withdrawal was popular with the US public. The ARVN grew from 820 000 in 1968 to over one million by 1971. US casualties dropped significantly: from 11 600 in 1969, to 6000 in 1970, and just over 2000 in 1971.



Make sure you can write a definition for these key terms

doctrine Vietnamisation fragging



Attacks on Cambodia (1970) and Laos (1971)

In 1970 and 1971, Nixon expanded the war into neighbouring Cambodia and Laos (see map on page 28) to cut the Ho Chi Minh Trail and stop the spread of communism.

Cambodia

- Cambodia was neutral in the Vietnam War until a pro-US general took over and demanded that the North Vietnamese leave in March 1970.
- In April 1970, around 80 000 ARVN and US troops invaded in support of the new government.
- Attacks were restricted to within 30 miles of the Vietnamese border.
- Around 11 000 communists were killed.
- Shocked, Congress revoked the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution in June.

Verdict: Failure

- ✗ Supply lines were not badly affected, as the Vietcong could use Laos instead.
- ✗ US public outrage increased.
- ✗ Anti-war protests in the USA intensified.

Laos

- Laos was also neutral in the war, with several groups fighting for power, some communist.
- In February 1971, the USA provided air support for an ARVN invasion of over 20 000 troops to sever the Ho Chi Minh Trail.
- 36 000 North Vietnamese counterattacked in March and drove the ARVN out of the country, causing heavy casualties.

Verdict: Failure

- ✗ Supply lines remained secure.
- ✗ North Vietnam's success led it to launch the Easter Offensive into South Vietnam with 120 000 troops in 1972.

The bombing of North Vietnam (1972)

In response to the Easter Offensive, Nixon launched Operation Linebacker on 6 April 1972. This was a bombing campaign to force North Vietnam to negotiate for peace. It lasted into October of that year.

Operation Linebacker was followed by a second operation – Linebacker II – in December 1972, which lasted 12 days, and killed over 1600 civilians.

- No restrictions: the key cities of Hanoi and Haiphong were bombed.
- Mines were dropped in Haiphong harbour and a naval blockade kept Chinese and Soviet ships away.
- The bombing nearly destroyed North Vietnam's war industry and severely disrupted supplies.

Verdict: Success

- ✓ On 26 December, urged on by its allies, North Vietnam agreed to resume peace negotiations with the USA.

Reasons for the failure of Vietnamisation

Vietnamisation failed for three main reasons:

South Vietnam	The economy suffered: 300 000 South Vietnamese lost their jobs as they were reliant on US troops. The government was weak, divided, and unpopular.
The ARVN	There was low morale and little will to fight; desertion was common. Training had been hurried; officers had limited experience. Corruption led to unsuitable appointments and supplies being sold off.
US troops	Troops knew the end was coming, so there was no incentive to risk their lives fighting.

Retrieval

Learn the answers to the questions below, then cover the answers column with a piece of paper and write down as many as you can. Check and repeat until you know them all.

Questions

- 1 How was President Johnson's popularity affected by the Vietnam War?
- 2 What did Nixon promise to end (other than the war) to gain popular support?
- 3 What was the 'Nixon Doctrine'?
- 4 What was Vietnamisation?
- 5 How many US troops were withdrawn from Vietnam by late 1969?
- 6 What happened to the ARVN as a result of Vietnamisation?
- 7 What happened to US casualties in Vietnam in the years after Vietnamisation began?
- 8 How did Vietnamisation affect US troops?
- 9 Which two countries did Nixon extend the war into, and when?
- 10 What effect did events in Cambodia have in the USA?
- 11 How did events in December 1972 change the course of the war?

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Answers

- His popularity dropped from 77% to 36%; people chanted 'Hey, hey, LBJ, how many kids did you kill today?'
- The draft
- Nixon's plan, put forward in July 1969, promising US allies in Asia support, including nuclear support, but no US troops would be involved
- Nixon's promise to provide military and financial support to the ARVN but to withdraw US troops
- 60 000
- It grew to over one million by 1971; however, the ARVN was badly led, had low morale, and was affected by corruption and incompetence
- They dropped significantly, from 11 600 in 1969 to just over 2000 in 1971
- The remaining US troops had very low morale, drug use was common, and fragging increased
- Cambodia (April 1970) and Laos (February 1971)
- Congress was shocked and revoked the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution; protest in the USA intensified
- 12 days of US bombing encouraged North Vietnam to agree to resume peace negotiations

Previous questions

Use the questions below to check your knowledge from previous chapters.

Questions

- 1 Why was the Till case unique in Mississippi history?
- 2 How comparable were the poverty rates for Black and white Americans by 1975?
- 3 By how much did Johnson increase the US military presence in Vietnam in the four years after Tonkin?

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Answers

- It was the first time white men had been tried for the murder of a Black man
- Black Americans were three times more likely to live in poverty
- In 1964 there were 23 000 US troops in Vietnam; by 1968 there were 536 000 US troops – an increase of 513 000

Practice

9

Exam-style questions

Study Source A below and then answer Question 1.

Source A: The motorcade of President Lyndon Johnson is attacked by anti-Vietnam War protesters in Melbourne, Australia. Protesters threw paint on the car, police, and Secret Service agents on 21 October 1966.



SOURCE TIP

Writing out a quotation or describing what is shown in an image does not show an inference. You need to extract information not explicit in the source. For example, what does the fact that the president's car is covered in paint suggest about the feelings of the surrounding crowd? What does the location of the photo suggest?

- 1 Give **two** things you can infer from Source A about President Johnson's approach to the Vietnam War. (4)

Complete the table below to explain your answer.

(i) What I can infer:

Details in the source that tell me this:

(ii) What I can infer:

Details in the source that tell me this:

- 2 Explain why Nixon took a different approach to the Vietnam War to Johnson. (12)

You **may** use the following in your answer:

- anti-war protest in the USA
- the ARVN

You **must** also use information of your own.

EXAM TIP

The prompts given here refer to two reasons why Nixon took a different approach to Johnson. Remember to use the prompts to explain why: for example, Johnson's increasing unpopularity (see Source A) and the benefits to the USA of training the ARVN.



10 Opposition to, and support for, the Vietnam War

Opposition to the war

Most people in the USA had no opinion on Vietnam during the Eisenhower (1953–61) and Kennedy (1961–63) years.

Johnson's decision to deploy ground troops from March 1965 led to a growing anti-war movement. Around 70% of the US public supported the war in 1965, and around 68% opposed it by 1971; both figures give the highest percentages of support for or against the war.

Reasons for the growth of opposition to the war:

- The Vietnam War was the first conflict broadcast widely on national TV. There was unprecedented, uncensored media coverage of the conflict.
- People felt the war was unfair (the USA was powerful and wealthy), unjustified, and carried the risk of becoming nuclear.
- Many young American men feared conscription from the draft. There was also a belief that the

draft targeted the poor whilst the rich escaped ('draft dodging').

- Key national figures opposed the war, including Martin Luther King, Muhammad Ali, and John Lennon.
- The costs of the war kept growing, both in terms of American lives lost and money – resulting in a tax increase in 1968.
- A growing student counter-culture movement, including the SDS (Students for a Democratic Society), rejected their parents' values and called for social change.
- There was a growing interest in Eastern spiritualism through the hippy movement, which was anti-war and challenged traditional values.
- In 1967, 'Vietnam Veterans Against the War' formed to protest against the war. They handed in medals received during the war and gathered evidence of atrocities committed.

The My Lai Massacre, 1968

Disastrous operations such as C Company's 'search and destroy' mission at the village of My Lai in March 1968 provided further fuel for anti-war protesters.

- US soldiers murdered around 500 civilians.
- The US military reported that they had successfully destroyed a Vietcong base.
- War photographer Sergeant Haeberle took pictures that helped expose the truth.
- The military cover-up was exposed and the lieutenant in charge put on trial. He was sentenced to life imprisonment, but his superiors were not charged.
- Lieutenant Calley was released by President Nixon after only serving three years.

The massacre and cover-up:

- increased public opposition to the war
- increased distrust of the US government
- harmed US soldiers' morale
- caused international condemnation.

However, My Lai was not a unique incident.

The Kent State shootings, 1970

Following the US invasion of Cambodia, around 500 students launched an anti-war protest at Kent State University, Ohio, on 1 May 1970. The protests escalated into violence and tragedy.

- As the number of protesters grew to 1000, fighting broke out between anti-war protesters and pro-war demonstrators.
- On 2 May, the Campus Officer Training Corps building was burnt down.
- The Mayor of Ohio declared a state of emergency and sent in troopers.
- On 4 May, around 3000 protestors held demonstration. When troopers ordered the protesters to leave, they refused and threw rocks.
- The state troopers retaliated, firing tear gas into the crowd, which threw more rocks. The troopers opened fire on the crowd, killing four students and injuring nine.

The shooting of white, middle-class students on a university campus horrified middle-class Americans and resulted in a storm of media attention.

Support for the war

People supported the Vietnam War for a variety of reasons, although support declined over time. Nevertheless, substantial numbers still supported military action after 1968, including some students.

US politicians were equally split between anti-war 'Doves' and pro-war 'Hawks'.

Reason for supporting the war	Explanation	Example
Fear of communism	Domino theory was a powerful influence on US public opinion. When China became communist, every country in Asia seemed at risk.	The Red Scare of 1950–53 was a 'witch hunt' of supposed communists in the USA.
Media support	Until 1968, most of the 600 US journalists in Vietnam were based in the relative safety of Saigon, and got their stories from the Joint US Public Affairs Office.	Walter Cronkite supported the war upto 1968; he was critical in turning US public opinion after that.
Patriotism	Many Americans were highly patriotic. They believed in the overwhelming power of the US Army and were certain that it was on the side of good, fighting for freedom and democracy. Challenging this was seen as treasonous.	Involvement in the Second World War and the defeat of the Nazis cemented the USA's place in world affairs. Americans did not want to 'lose face' in Vietnam.
'Hard hats'	Working-class white men, sometimes known as 'hard hats' (referring to hard hats worn in the construction industry), had often served in the US military and had sons who were fighting. Their support was unwavering.	In the 'hard hat' riot of 1970, 200 New York construction workers pushed through police to attack people protesting against the Kent State shootings.
The 'silent majority'	A large group of conservative, traditional Americans believed in the values of the USA and the government's duty to preserve them and spread them globally, but did not protest either for or against the war. They backed Nixon's call for an 'honorable peace'.	Nixon appealed to the 'great silent majority' in a speech in November 1969. A later poll showed that 77% supported his policies in Vietnam.
Peace negotiations	These began in 1968 in Paris. Occasional ceasefires and walk-outs occurred, but there was hope among the US public that the negotiations could end the conflict.	'Peace with Honor' was Nixon's description of the 1973 peace deal.
Political support	Political support was complicated by party politics, popular opinion, and desire for the USA not to appear defeated. The government was not always transparent or honest about the cost of its commitments, and the military continued to claim that victory was near.	After 1970, Congress began restricting the funds available for the war, but continued to make money available. US politicians feared a communist South Vietnam.

After Nixon's 'silent majority' speech, polls showed that many US citizens considered themselves part of that group. Both the House of Representatives and the Senate passed resolutions supporting Nixon's war policies.

Key terms

Make sure you can write a definition for these key terms

Red Scare patriotism 'hard hats' 'silent majority'

Retrieval

Learn the answers to the questions below, then cover the answers column with a piece of paper and write down as many as you can. Check and repeat until you know them all.

Questions

- 1 What year saw the highest percentage of people supporting the war in Vietnam?
- 2 What year saw the highest percentage of people opposing the war in Vietnam?
- 3 How did US media coverage of the Vietnam War increase opposition to it?
- 4 Which group felt most affected by the draft?
- 5 In what year did Congress approve a tax increase to pay for the Vietnam War?
- 6 What happened at My Lai in 1968 that increased opposition to the war?
- 7 What happened at Kent State University in 1970 that increased opposition to the war?
- 8 What was the biggest fear of those who supported the war?
- 9 Who were the 'hard hats'?
- 10 What phrase did Nixon use to describe the large numbers of US citizens who supported the war but were ignored by the media?
- 11 What percentage of Americans supported Nixon's war policies after his famous speech in November 1969?

- Put paper here
- 1965; around 70% of the population were in support of the war
- 1971; around 68% of the population were in opposition to the war
- The Vietnam War was the first conflict broadcast widely on national TV. There was unprecedented, uncensored media coverage of the conflict.
- Poor, young men
- 1968
- Over 500 unarmed Vietnamese civilians were killed by US soldiers; the massacre was covered up
- Four students were shot dead by state troopers during a protest against the Cambodia invasion
- That defeat might lead to a domino effect, which would mean an increase in communist countries
- Working-class men who supported the Vietnam War; many had served in the armed forces
- The 'silent majority'
- 77%
- Put paper here
- Put paper here

Previous questions

Use the questions below to check your knowledge from previous chapters.

Questions

- 1 How many children were arrested during the Birmingham campaign?
- 2 What happened to Diem in November 1963?
- 3 What was Vietnamisation?

- Put paper here
- Over 900
- He was removed by his own generals in a coup encouraged by the CIA, arrested, and shot dead
- Nixon's promise to provide military and financial support to the ARVN but to withdraw US troops

Practice



Exam-style questions

Study Sources A and B.

- 1 How useful are Sources A and B for an enquiry into opposition to the Vietnam War? Explain your answer, using Sources A and B and your knowledge of the historical context. (8)

Source A: An extract from an interview with Peter J. Brennan, president of the Building and Construction Trades Council of Greater New York, following the 'hard hat' riot of 1970.

Telephone calls and letters received by the unions were 20 to 1 in favor of the construction workers who were involved in a confrontation with antiwar demonstrators here last Friday. The demonstration was spontaneous. The unions had nothing to do with it, the men acted on their own. They did it because they were fed up with violence by anti-war demonstrators, by those who spat at the American flag and desecrated it. We've had calls and letters from all over the country praising the workers for their patriotism.

Source B: An extract from a speech entitled 'We ain't goin' delivered by Stokely Carmichael, leader of the SNCC, on 4 November 1967. (This source uses a racist term for Black people which was deeply offensive at the time and is considered to be unacceptable today.)

*You ought to recognize what's going on in that Vietnamese War. Here they taking you, training you to be a soldier, making you shine your shoes until three o'clock in the morning, going 8000 miles to shoot a man and he ain't never called you a n****r. Yeah. Now we are not only opposed [to] the war in Vietnam, we're opposed to compulsory conscription. We are against the draft. Now we're against the draft for anybody - Black or white.*

Study Interpretations 1 and 2. They give different views about opposition to the Vietnam War.

- 2 What is the main difference between these views? Explain your answer, using details from both interpretations. (4)

Interpretation 1: Adapted from *A People's History of the United States*, written by historian Howard Zinn in 1980.

The publicity given to the student protests created the impression that the opposition to the war came mostly from middle-class intellectuals. When some construction workers in New York attacked student demonstrators, the news was played up in the national media. However, a number of elections in American cities, including those where mostly blue-collar workers lived, showed that anti-war sentiment was strong in the working classes. For instance, in Dearborn, Michigan, an automobile manufacturing town, a poll as early as 1967 showed 41% of the population favored withdrawal from the Vietnam war.

Interpretation 2: Adapted from *A History of the United States*, written by historian Philip Jenkins in 1997.

Anti-war protest found an enthusiastic home in college campuses, and campus demonstrations and sit-ins became commonplace in the spring of 1968. Violent conflicts with police became even more frequent, as did active draft resistance and the destruction of draft cards. For conservatives, the protesters were literally committing treason against the nation and its soldiers, who were facing death on the battlefields of South East Asia. Anti-war militants even carried the Vietcong flag in demonstrations, deliberately seeking to enrage conservatives.

- 3 Suggest **one** reason why Interpretations 1 and 2 give different views about opposition to the Vietnam War. (4)
- 4 How far do you agree with Interpretation 1 about opposition to the Vietnam War? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. (16)

EXAM TIP

Question 3 invites you to also refer to the two sources from question 1 in your answer. This may help you to demonstrate different reasons why the interpretations differ.